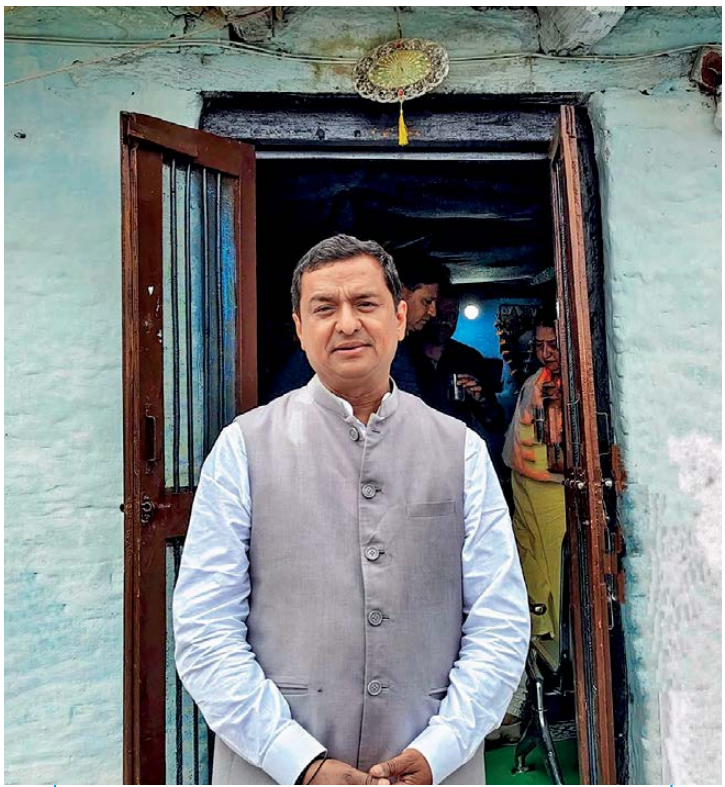
THE WRITE PLATFORM

Formerly members of the Fourth Estate, they will now occupy the seat of Indian democracy



X @ANIL_BALUNI

▲ ANIL BALUNI, *53*

| BJP | *Pauri Garhwal, Uttarakhand*

In 2002, a young Anil Baluni quit his job as a journalist in Delhi to return home to the newly-formed state of Uttarakhand to contest its first assembly polls. But his nomination from Kotdwar on a BJP ticket was rejected on technical grounds, and he later lost the re-election when that decision was overturned. Gujarat governor S.S. Bhandari made him his OSD then, and his active participation in BJP activities in Gujarat caught Narendra Modi's eye. He has risen since to become the party's national media in-charge and was also a Rajya Sabha MP in 2018. This time, he defeated Congress's Ganesh Godiyal by over 163,000 votes. An authority on the flora and fauna of Uttarakhand, Baluni continues to wield the pen, writing for dailies like *The Indian Express*.



▲ KALLISETTI APPALANAIDU, *50*

| TDP | *Vizianagaram, Andhra Pradesh*

A law graduate who began his career as a journalist, Appalanaidu joined the TDP two decades ago and became chairman of the Ponduru Marketing Committee in the constituency. Later, he was in charge of the TDP North Andhra training institute in Vizianagaram where he trained TDP cadre on governance. He had hoped to contest in 2019 from the Etcherla assembly seat, part of the Vizianagaram LS constituency, but it went to the BJP as part of the seat-sharing agreement. A member of the Turpu Kapu community, its sizeable population in Vizianagaram helped him beat the YSRCP's Bellana Chandra Sekhar by around 250,000 votes.

▼ RAMESH AWASTHI, *56*

| BJP | *Kanpur, UP*

In his three decades as a journalist, Ramesh Awasthi has worked, among other publications, with the Sahara Group. Associated with the RSS since his student days, he was a back-room worker of the BJP for long till the party decided to replace its sitting MP from Kanpur, Satyadev Pachauri, with him this time. Proving his worth, he defeated the SP's Alok Mishra. A member of the Centre's Hindi Official Language Advisory Committee, Awasthi also has a more interesting charge—organising the annual mango festival in Kanpur.



-Amarnath K. Menon, Anilesh S. Mahajan and Prashant Srivastava